A Beginner's Guide to Houseplant Care

This guide covers the basics of keeping common houseplants healthy, including watering, light, soil, and common problems.

Watering Basics

Most common houseplants should be watered when the top inch of soil feels dry to the touch. Overwatering is the most common cause of houseplant death, as it leads to root rot. As a general rule, water thoroughly until it drains from the bottom of the pot, then wait until the soil is dry again before watering next.

The Snake Plant only needs watering once every 2 to 3 weeks, since it stores water in its thick leaves. In contrast, the Peace Lily prefers consistently moist soil and will droop noticeably when it needs water.

Light Requirements

The Snake Plant tolerates low light well and can survive in a windowless room, though it grows fastest in bright indirect light. The Fiddle Leaf Fig requires bright, indirect light and will drop leaves if placed in a dark corner. Direct sunlight through a window can scorch the leaves of most tropical houseplants, including the Peace Lily and the Pothos.

Soil and Repotting

Most houseplants do best in a well-draining potting mix rather than garden soil, which retains too much water indoors. Succulents and cacti need an even faster-draining mix, often made with added sand or perlite.

Houseplants typically need repotting every 12 to 18 months, or when roots begin growing out of the drainage holes at the bottom of the pot. The best time to repot most plants is in spring, at the start of their active growing season.

Common Problems

Yellowing leaves are most often a sign of overwatering, not underwatering, despite being a common misconception. Brown, crispy leaf tips usually indicate low humidity or a buildup of minerals from tap water. Small flying insects around the soil surface are typically fungus gnats, which are attracted to consistently damp soil and can be reduced by allowing the soil to dry out more between waterings.

The Pothos Plant

The Pothos is considered one of the easiest houseplants for beginners. It tolerates low light, irregular watering, and a wide range of humidity levels. It can be grown in soil or in a jar of water indefinitely. The Pothos is toxic to cats and dogs if ingested, so it should be kept out of reach of pets.

Fertilizing

Houseplants generally only need fertilizer during their active growing season, spring through early fall. Most common houseplants should be fertilized once every 4 to 6 weeks during this period, using a balanced liquid fertilizer diluted to half strength. Fertilizing during winter dormancy can damage roots, since the plant is not actively using nutrients at that time.

Humidity

Tropical houseplants such as the Fiddle Leaf Fig and Peace Lily prefer higher humidity than most homes naturally provide, especially during winter when heating systems dry out indoor air. Grouping plants together, using a pebble tray with water, or running a humidifier nearby can all help raise humidity around sensitive plants.

Quick Reference Summary

Snake Plant: low light tolerant, water every 2-3 weeks, very low maintenance.

Pothos: low light tolerant, forgiving of irregular watering, toxic to pets.

Peace Lily: prefers moist soil, droops visibly when thirsty, avoid direct sun.

Fiddle Leaf Fig: needs bright indirect light, sensitive to low humidity, drops leaves if unhappy.